

Authenticity of Hadith and Credibility of the Stratification of Narrators: An Analysis of Imam Muslim

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Abstract

The classification of hadith into sahih, hasan and daif continues to be debated among scholars, particularly regarding the acceptance of daif narrations. Imam Muslim is frequently perceived as rejecting daif reports, accepting only sahih and hasan hadiths. This study examines Imam Muslim's techniques in evaluating and accepting hadith, emphasizing his meticulous and systematic methodology. His approach serves as a foundational blueprint for hadith authentication, providing scholars with a reliable framework for assessing accuracy and

credibility. Adopting a qualitative research design, this study relies on library-based data analyzed through content analysis methodology. It highlights the importance of understanding the methodology underlying hadith compilation, particularly the role of sanad analysis in preventing misinterpretation of the compiler's intent. The findings reveal that Imam Muslim structured Sahih Muslim based on the stratification of narrator credibility, rather than the later conventional classification of sahih, hasan and daif. By analyzing varying levels of narrator reliability, Imam Muslim employed a systematic and hierarchical approach to determine the acceptability of

narrations. His stratification system demonstrates an extraordinary degree of precision in verifying narrations, distinguishing his methodology as multi-layered, comprehensive and methodologically cautious. Rooted in the principle of ihtiyat (scholarly rigor and prudence), it reflects his exceptional diligence and critical discernment in determining the acceptance or rejection of hadith. Furthermore, this study emphasizes the significance of integrating digital isnad analysis and data-driven research methods to enhance the precision and scope of hadith evaluation, thereby bridging classical scholarship with contemporary technological advancements. This research ultimately assists modern scholars in understanding and applying Imam Muslim's authenticating framework within today's context of hadith studies.

Keywords: *Stratification; Credibility; Narrator; Blueprint; Sahih Muslim*

Introduction

Imam Muslim is renowned as one of the foremost hadith scholars, known for his exceptionally stringent criteria in accepting hadith. This meticulous approach is evident in the practices he applied in his seminal work *Sahih Muslim*. The compilation of *Sahih Muslim* began upon the request of his student, Ahmad bin Salamah (al-Dhahabi 1985 & al-Baghdadi 2002). This fact is explicitly mentioned by Imam Muslim in the introduction (*muqaddimah*) of his collection, as follows:

You have expressed a strong desire to gain knowledge of some of the hadiths attributed to the Messenger of Allah (peace be upon him) concerning religious practices, legal rulings, matters of reward and punishment, exhortations and warnings, as well as other

disciplines. These hadiths, along with their chains of transmission (*sanad*), are recognized among hadith scholars for their credibility, featuring *mutanaqilah* chains (specifically transmitted through narrators among the Companions and the Tabi'in) and *mutadawilah* chains (narrators from the subsequent generation after the Tabi'in) (Muslim n.d.).

The above statement indicates that the hadith book requested by Imam Muslim's companion must contain religious teachings and legal rulings, encompassing matters related to rewards and sins, encouragement and warnings, as well as other branches of religious discussions (Nur al-Din 'Itr 1981; Fawwaz 2020).

This request was not limited to the textual content (*matan*) of the hadith but also extended to its chain of transmission (*sanad*). In this regard, Muhammad Amin al-Harari opines that the term *sanad* mentioned is divided into two categories (al-Amin al-Harari 2009):

1. *Sanad Mutanaqilah*
 - Refers specifically to narrators among the Companions and the Tabi'in.
2. *Sanad Mutadawilah*
 - Refers to narrators after the Companions and the Tabi'in.

Additionally, al-Ityubi highlights that the sanad mentioned in the introduction refers to chains of transmission that are reliable and widely recognized among trustworthy (*thiqah*) hadith scholars (al-Ityubi 1424). Furthermore, Ahmad bin Salamah's second request was for these hadiths to be compiled into a single collection, as indicated in the following statement:

Thus, you desire—may Allah guide you—for those hadiths

to be compiled into a single collection (Muslim n.d.).

Subsequently, the third request was that the compiled hadiths should minimize repetition, making them easier to comprehend. This approach would also facilitate scholars in deriving legal rulings (*istinbat al-ahkam*) from them. This is stated in the introduction (*muqaddimah*) of *Sahih Muslim* as follows:

And you requested me to keep the writing concise, without including excessive repetition. You were concerned that such repetition might make it difficult for you to understand the hadiths and hinder the process of deriving legal rulings (*istinbat*) from them (Muslim n.d.).

Some of the requests made by Imam Muslim's student were accepted by him, while others were not, due to specific reasons. Imam Muslim agreed with Ahmad bin Salamah's suggestion to compile authentic hadiths (*sahih*) concisely in a single collection. This was because presenting a smaller number of authentic hadiths was deemed better than offering a large volume of narrations with varying degrees of reliability. This approach was particularly aimed at the general public, who lack the expertise and knowledge to distinguish the quality of hadiths unless guided by those with scholarly authority (Muslim n.d.).

However, Imam Muslim did not agree with the request to minimize repetition. According to him, for those well-versed in the science of hadith, there is valuable insight to be gained from repeated narrations. Imam Muslim further remarked that for the general public, “*Even a small number of hadiths may still be beyond their comprehension*” (Muslim n.d.).

Another factor that motivated Imam Muslim to produce his collection was the widespread circulation of weak (*daif*), rejected (*munkar*), abandoned (*matruk*), and even fabricated hadiths during his time. The most concerning aspect was that these narrations were often propagated by individuals who were aware of their flaws and falsifications (Muslim n.d.). This distortion of the Prophet's (peace be upon him) sayings was not a new phenomenon but had been occurring since the time of the Prophet himself (Khadher, Farhan & Khairulnazrin 2022). Thus, Imam Muslim agreed with his student's request to compile a work that adhered to strict criteria.

The *Sahih Muslim* was specifically written for those capable of benefiting from the diverse chains of transmission (*sanad*) presented within it. For the general public, however, a smaller selection of authentic hadiths would be more suitable and easier to comprehend compared to exposing them to the complexities of multiple chains of narration, which might include both authentic and weak (*daif*) reports. Such exposure would only lead to confusion among laypeople (Muslim n.d.).

Most of the literature on the methodology of *Sahih Muslim* concentrates on several core dimensions of Imam Muslim's scholarly framework. First, numerous studies analyse his criteria for selecting narrations and evaluating narrator credibility. These works highlight Muslim's emphasis on the dual pillars of narrator integrity (*'adalah*) and precision (*dabt*), alongside his insistence on verified transmission continuity (*ittisal al-sanad*) and demonstrable teacher-student contact (*liqa'* and *mu'asarah*) (al-Safdi 2015). Through this meticulous approach, Muslim is positioned not merely as a compiler of hadith, but as a critical evaluator (*naqid al-hadith*) with authoritative standing in the

discipline of *al-jarh wa-al-ta'dil*.

Second, a considerable body of research focuses on the role of *'ilal al-hadith* within *Sahih Muslim*. Many analyses demonstrate that Muslim intentionally incorporated narrations displaying subtle defects (*'illah*) for the purpose of methodological exposition, pedagogical illustration in *'ilm al-'ilal* and to elucidate textual and *isnad* variations among narrators (Hamzah al-Malyabari 1997). This indicates that his inclusion of such narrations was deliberate and pedagogically driven rather than accidental.

Third, a significant portion of the literature examines Muslim's highly systematic method of structuring the text. Scholars observe that *Sahih Muslim* is arranged with a primary sound transmission chain (*usul*) followed by corroborative narrations (*mutaba'at* and *shawahid*) (al-Mu'allimi, 1986). Although existing studies provide substantial technical analysis of Muslim's methodology, most remain descriptive and seldom engage with the epistemological implications of his approach. While previous research has primarily focused on *isnad* criticism, *'ilal* analysis and textual arrangement as separate areas of inquiry, these dimensions are rarely integrated into a unified analytical framework. Consequently, comparatively limited attention has been given to examining how Muslim's stratification of narrator credibility informs and intersects with broader interpretive principles in hadith evaluation.

In *Sahih Muslim*, each chain of transmission within a thematic unit is organized according to the stratification of narrator credibility (*al-ruwwah*). Such arrangement functions as an implicit mechanism for determining the strength and acceptance of a narration and reflects one of Muslim's distinctive methodological

features in presenting multiple reports on the same issue. Accordingly, Muslim's method of evaluating and accepting hadith demonstrates a rigorous, systematic and evidence-driven approach. His precise criteria for authentication have served as a foundational model for later scholars, providing a reliable framework for assessing the accuracy and credibility of narrations. This methodological diligence further mitigates interpretative error, ensuring that derived rulings and scholarly perspectives remain grounded in verified transmission.

Methodology

This study employs a critical review with an inductive approach, focusing on primary and secondary sources to analyze Imam Muslim's blueprint in authenticating hadith. The collected data will be systematically analysed through objective assessment and predefined thematic categories (Hardani et al. 2020). Primary data is derived from *Sahih Muslim*, while secondary sources include scholarly works and commentaries analyzing his techniques.

Fundamentally, this study examines a relatively underexplored methodological aspect of *Sahih Muslim*, namely the stratification of narrator credibility established by Imam Muslim in determining the acceptance or rejection of a narration. The research employs document analysis to investigate the criteria for narrator reliability, the structure of the chain of transmission and the classification of hadith, particularly *sahih*, *hasan* and *da'if*.

Accordingly, a descriptive thematic content analysis was adopted within a qualitative research framework. This method is considered appropriate for systematically identifying, analysing and interpreting thematic patterns (Clarke & Braun, 2020).

Through this approach, the study seeks to develop a coherent and comprehensive understanding of how Imam Muslim's systematic methodology serves as a foundational blueprint for hadith authentication.

Stratification Of Narrators' Credibility According To Imam Muslim

The Stratification of Narrators' Credibility According to Imam Muslim

There are various technical terms employed by hadith scholars to assess the credibility of hadith narrators before the status of a particular hadith can be determined (Wan Kamal & Noor Aileen 2024). However, the stratification of narrators' credibility (*al-ruwwah*) as conducted by Imam Muslim is unique and distinct from earlier scholars. For example, while Imam Ahmad employed specific criteria to determine the reliability (*thiqah*) of narrators, his approach differs from Imam Muslim's methodology (Al Kubaisi 2022). Typically, narrators are categorized into strata based on the types of hadith they transmit, such as narrators of *sahih* (authentic) hadiths, *hasan* (accepted) hadiths, *da'if* (weak) hadiths and those who fabricate hadiths. However, Imam Muslim applied a more detailed stratification, accepting narrators based on a meticulous classification of their credibility.

This approach is explicitly outlined in his introduction (*muqaddimah*). Imam Muslim stated that he would include hadiths categorized into three groups, corresponding to three distinct types of narrators (Muslim n.d.). Moreover, he explicitly mentioned that narrators belonging to the third category would not be included in his *Sahih*.

From Imam Muslim's statement about these three categories, one might infer that the hadiths he categorized correspond to the

classifications of *sahih*, *hasan* and *da'if*. Such an interpretation would lead to the conclusion that Imam Muslim rejected *da'if* hadiths outright. However, during his time, the division of hadith into these three categories had not yet been formally established. The earliest clear articulation of this tripartite classification is found in the introduction of al-Khattabi's works (al-Khattabi 1932). This underscores the importance of closely examining the *muqaddimah* of *Sahih Muslim* to fully understand Imam Muslim's methodology in compiling his collection.

The categorization mentioned by Imam Muslim in his *muqaddimah* is closely tied to the stratification of narrators (*al-ruwwah*). This is evident as, after describing the three categories, he provides examples of narrators corresponding to each classification. Thus, the categorization of hadith employed by Imam Muslim was fundamentally based on the stratification of narrators' credibility within the chains of transmission (*sanad*).

Among the narrators mentioned by Imam Muslim in his *muqaddimah* are 'Abdullah ibn 'Awn, Abu Ayyub al-Sakhtiyani, Mansur ibn al-Mu'tamir, 'Awf ibn Abi Jamilah, Ash'ath al-Humrani, al-A'mash, 'Ata' ibn al-Sa'ib, Yazid ibn Abi Ziyad, al-Layth ibn Abi Sulaym, 'Abd Allah ibn Miswar, 'Abd al-Quddus al-Shami, Sulayman ibn 'Amr, 'Abdullah ibn Muharrar, and others (Muslim n.d.).

An analysis of the principles of *jarh wa ta'dil* (criticism and validation) reveals that Imam Muslim categorized these narrators in a unique and systematic manner. This is evident in how narrators in the first category were arranged according to their levels within the hierarchy of *jarh* and *ta'dil*. For greater clarity, the study provides a detailed table listing the narrators, their levels, and their corresponding evaluations

of *jarh wa ta'dil* as described in the *muqaddimah*.

Table 1: Details of the Categorization of Hadith Narrators Based on the Stratification of Narrators' Credibility (*al-Ruwwah*)

FIRST STRATA			
('Ādil + Dābiṭ Tāmm)			
Bil	Name of Narrator	Status <i>Jarḥ Ta'dīl</i>	Hadith
1	‘Abdullah bin ‘Awn	<i>Thiqah Thabat Fadil</i>	Hadith narrated by a transmitter who is completely upright (' <i>ādil</i>) and possesses impeccable precision (<i>dabit</i>). [<i>Usul</i>]
2	Ayyub al-Sakhtiyani	<i>Thiqah Thabat Hujjah</i>	
3	Mansur bin al-Mu‘tamir	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>	
4	‘Awf bin Abi Jamilah	<i>Thiqah Rumiya bi al-Qadr wa bi al-Tasyayyu’</i>	
5	Ash‘at al-Humrani	<i>Thiqah Faqih</i>	
6	Al-A‘mash	<i>Thiqah Hafidh</i>	
7	Isma‘il bin Abi Khalid	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>	
SECOND STRATA			
('Ādil + Deficient in Dābiṭ)			
1	‘Ata’ bin al-Sa’ib	<i>Saduq Ikhtalat</i>	Hadith narrated by a transmitter who is either <i>mastur</i> (whose integrity is not fully established) or <i>ṣadūq</i> (trustworthy but not of the highest reliability). [<i>Shawahid</i> or <i>Tawabi’</i>]
2	Yazid bin Abi Ziyad	<i>Saduq</i>	
3	Al-Layth bin Abi Sulaym	<i>Saduq Ikhtalat Jiddan</i>	
THIRD STRATA			
(The defect in his justice (<i>al-‘adl</i>) and accuracy (<i>al-dabṭ</i>))			
1	‘Abdullah bin Miswar Abi Ja‘far al-Mada‘ini	<i>Wada’a Ahadith ‘an Rasulillah SAW</i>	Hadith narrated by a transmitter: 1. <i>Muttaham bi al-Kadhib</i> (Accused of lying) [<i>Matruk</i>] 2. <i>Kadhdhab</i> or <i>Dajjal</i> (Habitual liar or fraudster) [<i>Mawdu’</i>] 3. <i>Munkar</i> or <i>Kathrah al-Ghalat</i> (Known for excessive mistakes) [<i>Munkar</i>] [<i>Hadiths from this category are not transmitted.</i>]
2	‘Amru bin Khalid	<i>Matruk</i> dan dituduh sebagai <i>Kadhdhab</i> oleh Waki’	
3	‘Abd al-Quddus al-Shami	<i>Ahadithuhu Munkarah al-Isnad wa al-Matn</i>	
4	Muhammad bin Sa‘id al-Maslub	<i>Matruk</i>	
5	Ghiyath bin Ibrahim	<i>Taraka al-Nas Hadithahu</i>	
6	Sulayman bin ‘Amru Abi Dawud al-Nakha‘i	<i>Ma’ruf bi Wad’i al-Hadith</i>	
7	‘Abdullah bin Muharrar	<i>Matruk</i>	
8	Yahya bin Unaysah	<i>Da‘if</i>	
9	Al-Jarrah bin al-Minhal Abu al-‘Atuf	<i>Da‘if</i>	
10	‘Abbad bin Kathir	<i>Matruk</i>	
11	Husayn bin ‘Abdullah bin Dumayrah	<i>Matruk al-Hadith Kadhdhab</i>	
12	‘Umar bin Suhban	<i>Da‘if</i>	

Source: Researcher's Analysis

This table categorizes hadith narrators into three distinct strata based on their credibility and integrity, in accordance with Imam Muslim's methodology for evaluating the authenticity of narrations. So, the first strata is the highly reliable narrators with full integrity and precision. Second strata shown is the trustworthy narrators with some issues in precision, suitable for supporting narrations and also third strata for those who are unreliable with significant defects in both integrity and precision, whose narrations are generally rejected.

Based on the above details, it is evident that Imam Muslim exercised exceptional meticulousness in accepting narrators whose hadiths he included in his *Sahih*. The systematic arrangement and stratification of narrators' credibility (*al-ruwwah*) were not arbitrary but served significant purposes. These efforts were immensely beneficial not only to hadith scholars of his time but also to modern researchers studying hadith in subsequent eras.

Analysis of The Practice of Stratification of Narrators' Credibility According to Imam Muslim in Hadith Transmission

The Hadith of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) on Not Criticizing Food

To further clarify the practice of stratification of narrators' credibility (*al-ruwwah*) applied by Imam Muslim, one can examine the arrangement of hadiths discussing the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) not criticizing food, which includes:

Yahya bin Yahya, Zuhayr bin Harb, and Ishaq bin Ibrahim narrated to us—Zuhayr stated, Jarir narrated to us, while Yahya and Ishaq said, Jarir informed us—from al-A'mash, from Abu Hazim, from Abu

Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him), who said: The Messenger of Allah (peace and blessings be upon him) would never criticize any type of food. If he desired to eat it, he would do so and if he disliked it, he would leave it (Muslim n.d.).

In the subsequent hadith, Imam Muslim records only the chain of transmission (*sanad*) and indicates the text (*matn*) with the term “مثله” (similar), signifying that the text is identical to the preceding hadith. The chain of transmission for this narration is as follows:

Ahmad bin Yunus narrated to us, stating that Zuhayr narrated to us, who said: Sulaiman al-A'mash narrated to us through this chain of transmission (*sanad*) with content similar to the previous text (*matn*) (Muslim n.d.).

Subsequently, Imam Muslim presents another hadith with a different chain of transmission (*sanad*) and variation in wording (*lafz al-matn*), while maintaining the same underlying meaning (*ma'na*):

'Abd bin Humayd narrated to us, stating that 'Abd al-Razzaq, 'Abd al-Malik bin 'Amr, and 'Umar bin Sa'd Abu Dawud al-Hafari informed us—all of whom reported—from Sufyan, from al-A'mash, through this chain of transmission (*sanad*), with content similar to the preceding text (*matn*) (Muslim n.d.).

Imam Muslim further presents two final hadiths, which continue to discuss the same topic but with wording (*lafz al-matn*) that differs from the first three hadiths. These variations demonstrate slight differences in expression while maintaining the central

theme:

Abu Bakr bin Abi Shaybah, Abu Kurayb, Muhammad bin al-Muthanna, and ‘Amr al-Naqid narrated to us—(with the wording attributed to Abu Kurayb)—stating: Abu Mu‘awiyah informed us, who said: al-A‘mash narrated to us, from Abu Yahya Mawla Ali Ja‘dah, from Abu Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him), who said: “I have never seen the Messenger of Allah (peace and blessings be upon him) criticize any food. If he wished to eat it, he would do so, and if he did not wish to eat it, he would remain silent” (Muslim n.d.).

Subsequently, Imam Muslim states:

Abu Kurayb and Muhammad bin al-Muthanna narrated to us, both saying: Abu Mu‘awiyah narrated to us, (he said) from al-A‘mash, from Abu Hazim, from Abu Hurayrah, from the Prophet (peace and blessings be upon him), with the same hadith (Muslim n.d.).

The focal point (*madar*) of the chain of transmission (*sanad*) for this hadith is al-A‘mash, whose full name is Sulayman bin Mihran. He is recognized as a reliable and precise transmitter (*thiqah thabat*), with unanimous agreement among the scholars

of hadith regarding his credibility (al-Mizzi 1980). Thus, the hadith transmitted by al-A‘mash falls into the first category of hadiths mentioned by Imam Muslim in his introduction (*Muqaddimah*).

The narrators who transmitted from al-A‘mash include Jarir, Zuhayr, Sufyan al-Thawri and Abu Mu‘awiyah. They belong to the same stratum (*tabaqah*) in terms of their memorization (*hifz*), consistent adherence to their teacher, and precision in transmitting his narrations. Ibn Abi Khaytham remarked (Nur al-Din ‘Itr 2014):

I heard Yahya bin Ma‘in say: “There is no one more knowledgeable about the hadith of al-A‘mash than Sufyān al-Thawri.”

Ibn Abi Hatim also said (Nur al-Din ‘Itr 2014):

I heard my father say: “The most precise (*ahfaz*) student of al-A‘mash, who was most knowledgeable of his hadiths, is al-Thawri.”

Therefore, to evaluate the effectiveness of Imam Muslim's methodology in categorizing narrators into specific strata, the study will first detail the credibility of each narrator, beginning with the chain of the first hadith and ending with the last hadith. Below is the detailed analysis of *jarh* and *ta‘dil* by the scholars regarding each narrator in the chains of narration:

Table 2. Detailed Evaluation (*Jarh wa Ta‘dil*) of the Narrators in the Chain of Transmission (*Sanad*)

Hadith 1		
Name of Narrator	Date of Death	Term of Jarh and Ta‘dil
Imam Muslim		
Yahya bin Yahya	226H	<i>Thiqah Thabat Imam</i>
Zuhayr bin Harb	234H	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>
Ishaq bin Ibrahim	238H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz Mujtahid</i>

Jarir	188H	<i>Thiqah Sahih al-Kitab</i>
Al-A'mash	147H @ 148H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Hazim	100H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Abu Hurayrah	57H	<i>Sahabah</i>
Nabi Muhammad SAW		

Hadith 2		
Name of Narrator	Date of Death	Term of Jarh and Ta'dil
Imam Muslim		
Ahmad bin Yunus	227H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Zuhayr	172H @ 173H @ 174H	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>
Al-A'mash	147H @ 148H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Hazim	100H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Abu Hurayrah	57H	<i>Sahabah</i>
Nabi Muhammad SAW		

Hadith 3		
Name of Narrator	Date of Death	Term of Jarh and Ta'dil
Imam Muslim		
'Abd bin Humayd	249H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
'Abd al-Razzaq	211H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
'Abd al-Malik bin 'Amr	204H @ 205H	<i>Thiqah</i>
'Amar bin Sa'ad Abu Dawud al-Hafari	203H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Sufyan al-Thawri	161H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz Faqih 'Abid Imam Hujjah</i>
Al-A'mash	147H @ 148H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Hazim	100H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Abu Hurayrah	57H	<i>Sahabah</i>
Nabi Muhammad SAW		

Hadith 4		
Name of Narrator	Date of Death	Term of Jarh and Ta'dil
Imam Muslim		
Abu Bakr bin Abi Shaybah	235H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Kurayb	247H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Muhammad bin al-Muthanna	252H	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>
'Amr al-Naqid	232H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Mu'awiyah	295H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Al-A'Mash	147H @ 148H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Yahya	-	<i>Maqbul</i>
Abu Hurayrah	57H	<i>Sahabah</i>
Nabi Muhammad SAW		

Hadith 5		
Name of Narrator	Date of Death	Term of Jarh and Ta'dil
Imam Muslim		
Abu Kurayb	247H	<i>Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Muhammad bin al-Muthanna	252H	<i>Thiqah Thabat</i>
Abu Mu'awiyah	295H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Al-A'Mash	147H @ 148H	<i>Thiqah Thiqah Hafiz</i>
Abu Hazim	100H	<i>Thiqah</i>
Abu Hurayrah	57H	<i>Sahabah</i>
Nabi Muhammad SAW		

Source: Researcher's Analysis

This is the sequence of narrators who have transmitted a hadith, each of whom must be evaluated for their credibility. Table 2 summarize the breaks down the evaluation of narrators in a specific hadith's chain of

transmission. Each narrator is assessed based on their character, memory and reliability, with an explanation of their classification according to established scholarly criteria.

Table 3. Comparison of the Chains of Transmission (*Sanad*) for the Hadith "The Messenger of Allah Did Not Criticize Food"

MUSLIM BIN AL-HAJJAJ	Yahya bin Yahya	Zuhayr bin Harb	Ishaq bin Ibrahim	Jarir	Al-A'mash	Abu Hazim	Abu Hurayrah	RASULULLAH SAW
			Ahmad bin Yunus	Zuhayr	Al-A'mash	Abu Hazim	Abu Hurayrah	
	'Abd al-Razzaq	'Abd al-Malik bin 'Amr	'Amar bin Sa'ad Abu Dawud Al-Hafari	Sufyan al-Thawri	Al-A'mash	Abu Hazim	Abu Hurayrah	
	Abu Kurayb	Muhammad bin al-Muthanna	'Amr al-Naqid	Abu Mu'awiyah	Al-A'mash	Abu Yahya	Abu Hurayrah	
		Abu Kurayb	Muhammad bin al-Muthanna	Abu Mu'awiyah	Al-A'mash	Abu Hazim	Abu Hurayrah	

Source: Researcher's Analysis

This table shown that the purpose of such a detailed evaluation is to ensure the authenticity of the hadith. By scrutinizing each narrator's character and the accuracy of their transmission, scholars can determine whether the hadith in question is genuine and reliable. This process helps preserve the integrity of Islamic traditions and teachings by filtering out weak or fabricated narrations. Based on the analysis of the aforementioned chains of transmission (*sanad*), Imam Muslim has clarified that he does not repeat hadiths unless there is a specific purpose, such as highlighting an addition (*ziyadah*) or addressing a contradiction (*mukhalafah*) within the chain, which may indicate the presence of a defect (*'illah*) in the narration.

This matter is significant because, if Imam Muslim had only included the narration of Jarir, there is a concern that it might be

perceived as an isolated narration (*tafarrud*). This is due to the fact that Jarir is not considered the most prominent student of al-A'mash, as previously mentioned (Nur al-Din 'Itr 2014). Therefore, the narration of Zuhayr is included as corroboration (*mutaba'ah*) for the narration of Jarir, as it is transmitted with identical wording. This is evidenced by Imam Muslim's use of the term (*mithlahu*) when presenting the narration through the chain of Zuhayr.

Subsequently, Imam Muslim presents the narration of Sufyan al-Thawri, indicating that this narration was transmitted in meaning (*riwayah bi al-ma'na*). He alludes to this by using the term (*nahwahu*). Sufyan al-Thawri is regarded as the most reliable student of al-A'mash in transmitting hadiths originating from him.

The transmission route of Abu Mu'awiyah from al-A'mash is based on the narrator Abu Yahya Mawla Ali Ja'dah. This differs from the transmission routes of other students of al-A'mash, whose narrations are based on Abu Hazim.

Al-Daraqutni commented that there is a defect ('illah) in the transmission of al-A'mash from Abu Yahya. This conclusion is based on a comparison between the narrations of Jarir, Zuhayr and Sufyan al-Thawri with that of Abu Mu'awiyah from al-A'mash, highlighting discrepancies between the narrations transmitted through Abu Hazim and those through Abu Yahya.

This is supported by the transmission route of Abu Mu'awiyah from al-A'mash through Abu Hazim, which is mentioned after the narration from Abu Mu'awiyah from al-A'mash through Abu Yahya, with identical wording. Such repetition is only undertaken for specific reasons, including the presence of an addition (*ziyadah*) or to clarify a defect ('illah) in a particular chain of transmission (*sanad*) (Muslim n.d.). Therefore, the narration through Abu Mu'awiyah from al-A'mash via Abu Yahya is considered problematic due to its

contradiction (*mukhalafah*) and isolation (*tafarrud*) in comparison to the other chains of transmission.

Thus, the stratification of the credibility of the narrators (*al-ruwwah*) serves its purpose and plays a crucial role in elucidating the defects ('illah) within a hadith, ultimately revealing Imam Muslim's methodology in accepting specific narrations included in *Sahih Muslim*.

The Hadith on the Virtue of Praying in the Prophet's Mosque (SAW)

The hadith regarding the virtue of praying in the Prophet's mosque (SAW) has been a topic of significant debate between two prominent hadith scholars of the Arabian Peninsula, Rabi' al-Madkhali and Hamzah al-Malyabari. In the context of this narration, Imam Muslim includes various narrations on the subject of prayer in the Prophet's mosque in *Sahih Muslim* (Muslim n.d.). Based on the overall chains of transmission (*sanad*), these hadiths are narrated by only three companions: Abū Hurayrah, Ibn 'Umar and Maymunah. Furthermore, each chain of transmission can be represented as follows:

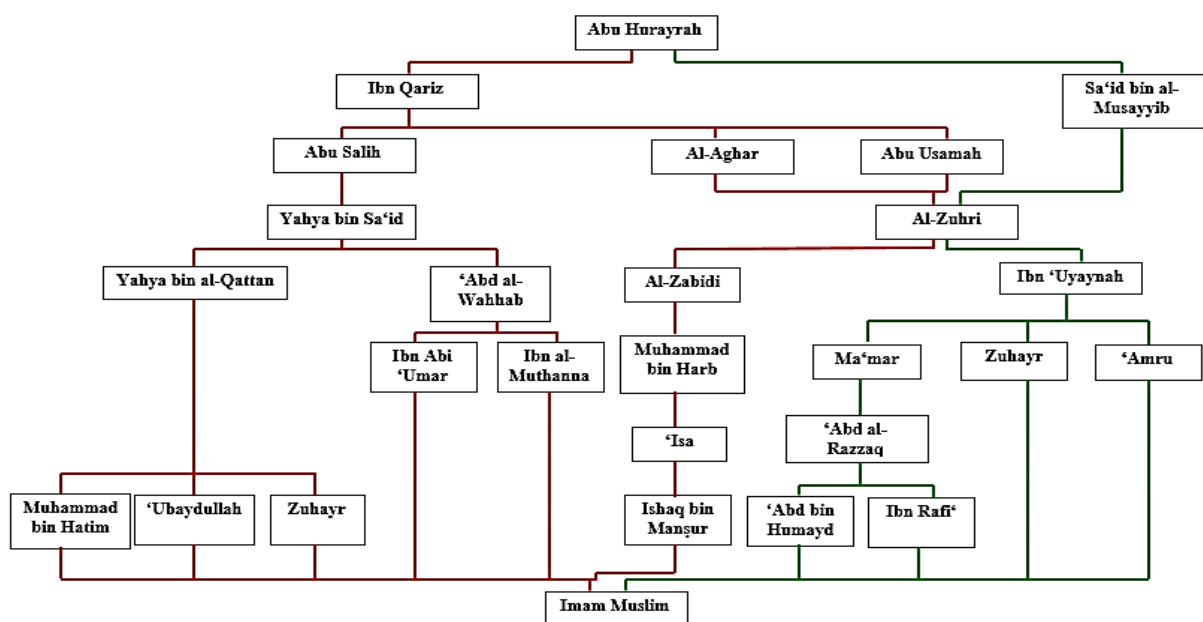


Figure 1. The Root Chain of Transmission for the Narration of Abu Hurayrah

Based on the chain of transmission diagram above, Imam Muslim prioritizes the transmission route from Sa'id bin al-Musayyib over that of 'Abdullah bin Ibrahim bin Qariz. This is because Sa'id bin al-Musayyib is considered more reliable (*awthaq*) than Abdullah bin Ibrahim bin Qariz. As mentioned by Ahmad bin 'Ali Manjuyah, Sa'id bin al-Musayyib is

regarded as the most knowledgeable regarding the hadiths of Abu Hurayrah ('Ali Manjuyah 1407).

Next, the study will present the chains of transmission originating from Ibn 'Umar and Maymunah. Below is the diagram illustrating the root chains of transmission for both sources:

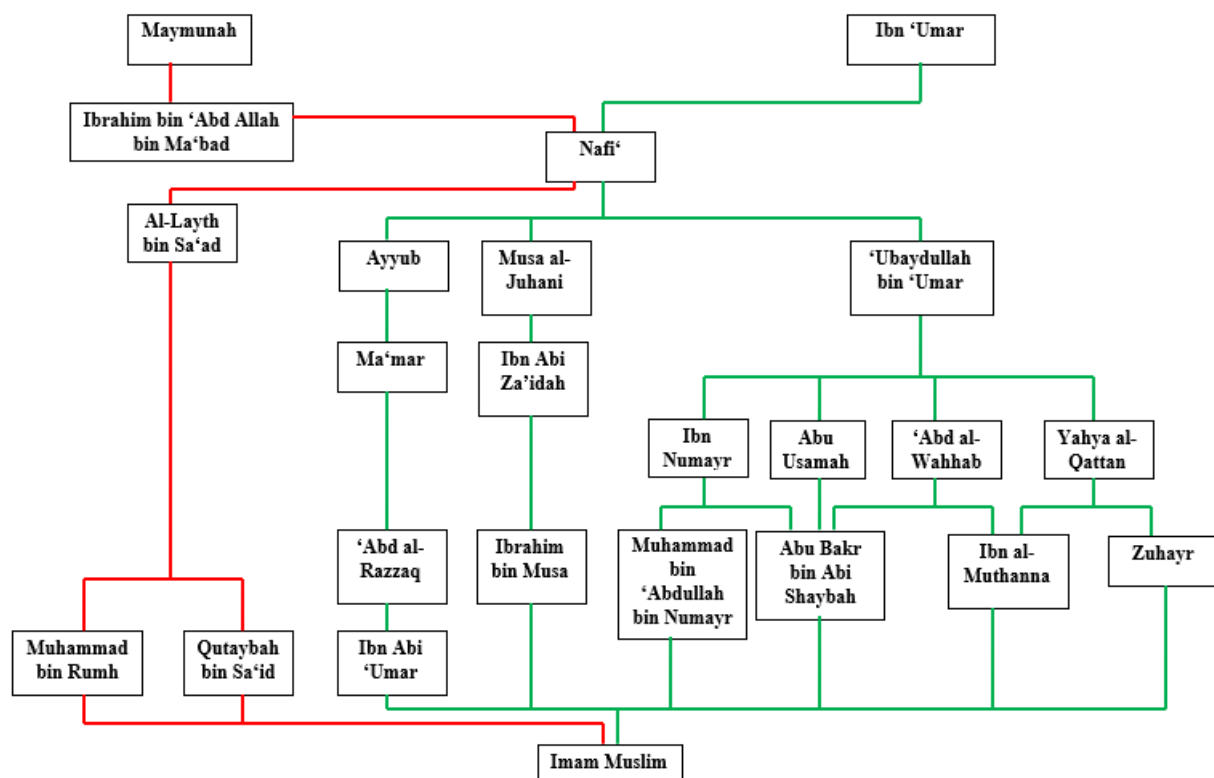


Figure 2. The Root Chain of Transmission for the Narrations of Ibn 'Umar and Maymunah

As observed in the diagram above, Hamzah al-Malyabari indicates that Imam Muslim is implying a discrepancy in the narration of Nafi'. Due to this contradiction, the expert scholars (*nuqqad*) critiqued the hadith of Ibn 'Umar, as it is considered more prone to error compared to the narration from al-Layth bin Sa'ad, which is regarded as stronger (Hamzah al-Malyabari 2004). Furthermore, al-Daraqutni stated that the chain of transmission from Ayyub, from Nafi', from Ibn 'Umar is not authentic

(*ghayr mahfuz*) (Abu al-Hasan 1985). Similarly, al-Bukhari preferred the narration of al-Layth bin Sa'ad over that of Ibn Jurayj when discussing the hadith regarding the virtue of praying in the Prophet's mosque (SAW) (al-Bukhari n.d.).

Based on this example, it is clear that the stratification approach of the narrators (*al-ruwwah*) employed by Imam Muslim in his *sahih* is intended to determine whether a particular hadith is accepted or rejected by

him. This approach highlights the purpose of compiling various chains of transmission for a hadith within the same theme not merely for collection, but with specific objectives, such as clarifying defects (*'illah*), additions (*ziyadah*), determining the acceptance of a narration and other related purposes.

The findings of this study demonstrate that Imam Muslim's methodology for determining hadith authenticity, grounded in a stratified framework of narrator credibility, functions as a systematic and comprehensive blueprint. To strengthen these findings, it is essential to contextualize Imam Muslim's approach within the broader tradition of hadith authentication. This includes comparative engagement with other authoritative methods, such as general evaluation of the *sanad* and *matn*, the methodology of *jarh wa ta'dil* and the critical frameworks developed by subsequent scholars including al-Nasa'i, al-Tirmidhi, Ibn Hibban, and Ibn al-Salah. Such comparison not only highlights Imam Muslim's unique contribution to the science of hadith, but also underscores how his methodology has served as a foundational reference in shaping a more systematic and rigorous discipline of hadith criticism within the Islamic scholarly tradition.

Furthermore, the findings reaffirm the critical importance of stratifying narrator credibility in the process of hadith evaluation. Imam Muslim did not merely classify narrators as *thiqah* or otherwise, rather he introduced nuanced layers of assessment based on differing levels of memory precision, transmission accuracy and continuity of the transmission chain. This approach offers a deeper and more refined analytical framework that functions as a key criterion in distinguishing *sahih*, *hasan* and *da'if* reports. Accordingly, the stratification system adopted by Imam

Muslim not only reflects an extraordinary degree of precision in authenticating narrations, but also sets his methodology apart as a multi-layered, highly detailed and methodologically cautious system. It is firmly grounded in the principle of *ihtiyat* (scholarly rigor and prudence), demonstrating exceptional care in determining the acceptance or rejection of hadith.

Conclusion

The discussion reveals that it is crucial to understand the background of the compilation of a hadith collection with its chain of transmission (*sanad*) carefully, in order to avoid misinterpretation of the true intent conveyed by the author. Imam Muslim organized the hadiths included in *Sahih Muslim* based on the stratification of the credibility of each narrator in every chain of transmission. Therefore, the categorization made by Imam Muslim is based on the stratification of credibility, rather than the classification of hadiths into *Sahih*, *hasan* and *da'if*. The study finds that Imam Muslim employs the stratification of the credibility of the narrators (*al-ruwwah*) in determining whether a narration is accepted or rejected. Also, this study contributes to the understanding of Imam Muslim's blueprint in the acceptance of hadiths within his renowned compilation, *al-Sahih*. By examining the stratification of narrator credibility, this research offers a comprehensive analysis of Imam Muslim's systematic approach to the selection and evaluation of hadiths. It provides scholars with a more nuanced understanding of the process through which Imam Muslim assessed the authenticity of narrations, emphasizing the critical role of narrator credibility within the chain of transmission. Consequently, this study not only enriches the academic discourse surrounding Imam Muslim's criteria for hadith acceptance but also offers valuable guidance for

contemporary scholars in evaluating the reliability and authenticity of narrations based on the integrity of their transmitters. Moreover, by suggesting the integration of digital *isnad* analysis and data-driven research methods, this study highlights how modern technological tools can further enhance the precision and scope of ḥadīth evaluation. This integration serves to bridge classical methodologies with contemporary advancements in the study of prophetic traditions.

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